

Google's Chrome OS

Just when the crowds were getting excited about Google's mobile operating system, Android, there came some even more exciting news from Google. Google is developing an operating system based on the Chrome browser. Users are not just content with the free services, and many have hoped that Google would create an operating systems; and it's finally happening!

While many have their fingers crossed that Chrome OS will take on Microsoft's Windows operating system, it's highly unlikely there'll be such a confrontation. Google would need to use its power to convince developers to port applications previously developed for Windows over to its platform. That's a tall order. If Google integrates its online services with the local operating system, it could take a large chunk from the netbook OS market and also many Linux distributions.

Not much is known about it yet. It will be built on a Linux kernel and will be designed for low power computing devices – netbooks. The OS is said to be developed together with companies such as HP, ASUS, Adobe, Texas Instruments. Chrome OS will be coded for the ARM processor.

Google says that it doesn't want people to be spending all their time waiting for computers to boot up and load software. It also doesn't want people to lose any data. It is clearly suggesting that the cloud is the way to go, and if so, powerful hardware isn't required. Our only

concern is the poor internet connectivity options available in our country. With most users on connections with ridiculous download caps and limited speeds, running an operating system that depends heavily on the internet might not be practical.

Chrome OS will be free because it will be open source. Many say that the code for the

OS will be made public already this year. It should be available for public release in the later half of next year.

Amazon pulls a disappearing act

Imagine you pay for something and one fine day the vendor who sold it to you, just takes it away. Amazon recently did precisely that with one of the books sold to customers on the Kindle ebook reader. Ironically, the book that Amazon chose to erase from customer's devices was 1984, the George Orwell classic which depicts a totalitarian era where this sort of a thing would've been commonplace.

Apparently, Amazon discovered that the copy on sale with them was a bootleg version. When the original copyright holder notified Amazon about this, Amazon decided not to just discontinue selling it but also to pull it out of customers' Kindles. As compensation, Amazon refunded the customers. Still, as expected, the incident generated a lot of gripe online. It is generally agreed that Amazon handled a genuine problem, very badly indeed.

Customers buy ebooks for the Kindle device over a wireless network, but who knew the device had hidden functionality built in that could invoke a reversal remotely?

Another title by the same author, Animal Farm, was also zapped in this sweep. And as it turns out this is not the first instance of Amazon pulling this stunt. Customers voicing their complaints on forums have pointed out earlier instances of Harry Potter books disappearing. Several users likened it to stealing property from their bedside table, while they were asleep. Kindle owners have first to contend with the fact that ebooks, however tangible, have certain limitations when compared to physical books. These include not being able to lend books, to resell or donate them once read, and also the inability to display them on a bookcase. Now they even have to live in fear of the

books disappearing from their devices at the will of the seller. Another twist to this incident is that the books that were forcibly recalled are freely available for download on websites from countries where the copyright has expired, example Russia.

Microsoft donates code to Linux

Microsoft did something that few could have predicted: it submitted 20,000 lines of code



to the Linux community under a GPLv2 license.

The code is meant for four drivers which allow Linux operating systems to run on the latest version of the Windows Server using virtualisation. It's code-named Viridian and commonly called Hyper-V. With this code Linux servers should be able to run on Windows Server 2008's Hyper-V virtualisation system with a minimal performance loss. So why is Microsoft apparently trying to help Linux? With better support and performance for Linux on its Windows servers, it might be hoping to improve sales. On the other hand, Microsoft has been saying that Linux violates 235 of its patents, ranging from the kernel right up to the user interface.

This move seems to have put some pressure on VMware which is a major player in the virtualisation scene. It has

